VIRTUOSO GUIDE TO CAREERS

Achieve your academic and career goals – in your own way, on your own terms

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Academic and Professional Development Matter to Virtuosos

Virtuosos may struggle more than other personality types within the confines of the traditional structures of society – so much so that their unusual type of genius may go overlooked in both academic and professional environments. Naturally, this can shake their confidence, compounding the fact that, as Introverts, they may struggle to promote their natural talents and skills. This is precisely why it is so important for Virtuosos to explore the relationship between personality and academic and professional development. When they become aware of certain tendencies, they can take the steps necessary to improve outcomes and "make things work" in the way that most looks like success for them.

Whether in the workplace or at school, Virtuosos are brilliant in hands-on fields that combine creativity with unpredictability. To them, practical experience matters more than theories or abstractions, and so they devote their time to experimenting, tinkering, and *doing* rather than planning and reflecting.

Mechanical projects often draw in people with this personality type. As a result, many Virtuosos find themselves in engineering or related fields. To some personality types, mechanics and engineering may seem to be plodding, cut-and-dried pursuits. In these areas, however, Virtuosos harness their trademark spontaneity and energy, unleashing these traits when they find the right ventures. The drive, effort, and creativity that Virtuosos expend on their passion projects can be quite startling to outsiders.

In addition to mechanics and engineering, Virtuosos shine in fields that force them to leverage their creativity in crises or time-sensitive situations. As a result, Virtuosos can excel as emergency response personnel, athletes, or even racers. These fields satisfy them on several levels, allowing them to experience adrenaline rushes, break the rules of everyday life, and sometimes even save lives, all at the same time.

Whatever form their studies and their careers take, Virtuosos need environments where they can follow their instincts and be true to themselves. Provided that they find such settings, they can bring their greatest strengths to their endeavors, addressing issues on the fly and creating innovative, even groundbreaking solutions to the problems that they face.

In these pages, we'll discuss how Virtuosos can bring the full force of their strengths to their academic and professional pursuits – and how they can stay motivated and make progress toward their longer-term goals. Along the way, we'll cover how Virtuosos can overcome challenges that people with their personality type often experience, including how to find common ground with those who don't see eye to eye with them and how to see the "big picture" without losing their spontaneous edge.

When they harness their talents and work through their weaknesses, Virtuosos often find that their observational skills, creativity, and quick thinking are exactly what they need to achieve their version of success.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Academic Path

Virtuosos are naturally curious individuals with a love of learning new skills, especially those that have a practical benefit. True to their name, they see education as an opportunity to gain knowledge and skills they can then apply to whatever interests they have. A rock climbing enthusiast, for example, may pursue a degree in geology to learn more about the formations that they're in such close contact with.

Whatever path they decide to take in their lives, Virtuosos can benefit from embracing the power of education and looking for learning opportunities whenever possible. Whether they're learning about medieval history in the classroom or teaching themselves how to build websites in their own home, Virtuosos can benefit from expanding their minds and increasing their skills.

Let's discuss how Virtuosos learn best, what struggles they may face in academic environments, and how they can improve their lifelong learning habits.

How Virtuosos Learn

Balanced Learning Habits

Hands-On and Spontaneous Experiences

Learning that involves hands-on mastery and allows for spontaneous learning experiences interests Virtuosos most. They learn best in loose, unstructured environments with malleable, free-form curricula with an emphasis on the experiential. Virtuosos respond to a high level of personal involvement in their learning, especially if they're focused on mastering the topic.

Students with the Virtuoso personality type tend to understand that paying attention to the whole academic package supports their ability to pursue their area of interest. While they're usually restless in a lecture hall setting, if they discover an alternate niche – like athletics or mechanics – they can sometimes generalize their new passion and apply to other subjects and methods they find less palatable. Even so, Virtuosos dislike just sitting still and absorbing information – ask them to recall a historical timeline, for example, and their eyes are likely to glaze over. But give them something practical to do and they'll engage wholeheartedly. Allow them to express themselves in an interesting and amusing fashion and they shine.

Virtuosos also enjoy coaching and feedback on their performance. While nobody likes criticism, they're serious about mastering what interests them and appreciate any honest observations that can help them improve. The optimal learning style for Virtuosos is to observe someone modeling a technique, immediately performing the same technique themselves, and then receiving feedback on their performance. Once they mature and gain mastery, they're likely to put their own spin on their work.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Loathing Traditional Structure

Even Virtuosos with the most balanced approach to learning can struggle in an overly structured, traditional classroom setting, but this issue is much worse for those who take an unbalanced approach. Unfortunately for these types, most academic settings focus on providing structure for students as if everyone learns in the same way. Since most of the population is made up of Sentinel personality types, most educational institutions consistently reinforce the idea that structured curricula work best.

This system doesn't work well for Explorers, including Virtuosos who are, ostensibly, the anti-Sentinels. (This doesn't mean they don't like Sentinels or are against them. Rather, they work in an almost opposite manner.) Sentinels are rules-based and like to uphold tradition. They're orderly and think in linear ways. They prefer traditional classrooms that

largely favor the predictable and the routine. Virtuosos struggle in such restrictive environments.

Sentinels dominate our society and set the standards for what most accept now as good pedagogy in most educational systems. In fact, Sentinels are highly represented among teachers and school administrators. For most people, this is an important service Sentinels offer society. However, it can clearly present real challenges for the Virtuosos in their classrooms.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Seeking Opportunities for Spontaneity

Parents and instructors who want to reach Virtuosos and engage them in the learning process may need to help them find their forte and provide them with opportunities to be spontaneous. To do this, they can try giving these students something to do on their own that gives them some freedom to express themselves. Virtuoso students generally respond to instruction that has a feeling of boldness and spontaneity to it. Always looking for something new and novel, they like to reach decisions or conclusions in their own time based on what they discover.

However, once they discover it, they may not wait around for others before they implement it. Instructors should include enough flexibility to accommodate this in order to keep their Virtuoso students from becoming bored or disruptive.

Still, it's important to remember that Virtuosos can only take so much spoon-feeding before they go off on their own. Parents and instructors must allow them plenty of time to work on projects on their own schedules and in their own ways. It's also worth remembering that Virtuosos enjoy working with others and need a wide range of activities rich in personal involvement. Too much seclusion or time spent working on assignments alone can also cause impatience and boredom.

Group work can be more stimulating for these types, especially with group members who model the skills they're learning. Being involved

with a group dissecting frogs for biology is likely to provide much more significant learning outcomes for these types than labeling the anatomy of a frog on a worksheet or writing a report about the biology of a specific type of frog.

Virtuosos in High School

If you've been to high school, you don't have to watch one of the thousands of films about teenage angst to know that there's more to high school than just classes. Most would agree there are as many lessons in the schoolyards and hallways of high schools as there are in classrooms. Let's take a moment to consider high school as a place where some important social and academic lessons unfold.

Balanced High School Learning

Bold and Innovative

Virtuosos can be reclusive, especially if they feel out of place in the classroom. However, those Virtuoso students who understand themselves and find their niche can offset this with their natural charm and boldness. They often come across as the strong, silent type who can deliver a potent one-liner. Associating with Virtuosos may even appeal to the rebellious streak in some of their otherwise conventional peers.

They're not often found in leadership positions, but this is through their own preference. As a type that doesn't like structure, they aren't likely to impose it on others. If they find a high school group that interests them enough to join, they're likely to show great passion and commitment. Virtuosos often serve throughout life in advisory capacities and can offer a lot to a group by coming up with innovative ways for it to express itself. They also thrive on solving problems and typically do a great job of discovering solutions.

Extracurricular activities are a prime example of Virtuosos engaging in the "system" in ways that best suit them. They may investigate joining clubs or groups that reflect their pursuits in order to be with like-minded people, but it's more likely they'll want to pursue those

passions on their own and in their own ways. If they join something, it's most likely to be groups involved with activities that are more physical than cerebral and skills-based more than theoretical. Any clubs that build things would suit them well, such as building sets, robots, or car engines. They may also be inclined to join sports teams, which can feed their need to be active, to strategize, and perhaps even put them at reasonable – yet exciting – risk.

Unbalanced High School Learning

Out of Sync with the System

Frankly, Virtuosos often have a difficult time in high school. The typical classroom just isn't a great fit for them. Their preferences and learning styles may be so at odds with what happens in the average classroom that they come across as troublemakers or as being "not so bright." Within the traditional system, it's easy to miss the genius of a fairly unusual type lurking below the surface in such students. Unfortunately, too many teachers and parents lack this perspective, and they often view Virtuosos as uncooperative or incapable.

Let the other students memorize cold, hard facts or play with ideas, but make sure Virtuosos have something practical and tangible to do and watch them succeed. In high school, point them toward mechanical skills or others that need mastery. If left to struggle with traditional forms of education, Virtuosos are likely to not only suffer poor grades, but they may find the emotional and psychological distress to be painful. Too often, the message they receive from their school environment is that they're out of sync with everyone else. If it's constantly made clear to them that they don't fit in, it can cause a great deal of damage to their self-esteem.

Rebalancing High School Learning

Relating Learning to Personal Interests

When they find activities they connect with, Virtuosos are likely to do more than put in a great deal of effort to master it; they'll probably tolerate time spent in the passive lecture hall better. Virtuoso students

settle down and apply themselves more to school work when they find their niche or, in effect, find themselves.

These types enjoy a wide range of interests, and if they're allowed to express themselves in ways true to their nature, they can sometimes find more patience for subjects that wouldn't normally fit their interests. With a sense of fulfillment, it won't feel like they're denying themselves to commit to their studies. Once Virtuosos feel able to pledge themselves to something – in this case, high school – they're passionate and loyal people.

Work or College?

While many other reasons other than personality types are involved in deciding whether to go college, they can play a role in the equation. Recently, most people thought of a college or university degree as the quickest route to success and security. Now, some of these same people vigorously argue against higher education for everyone. We've watched college dropouts succeed on a grand scale in our technological age, with Steve Jobs and Bill Gates being the two most famous examples.

There are niches for everyone, and college is just one possible path to finding them. So, what might Virtuosos consider when deciding between going to university or going to work?

It's easy to see action-conscious Virtuosos wanting to get out into the world quickly to perform and produce. However, their intrinsic need to master their craft can be just as insistent as their need to perform, making them the two things these types must weigh and balance when thinking about college.

If they have an image of it as a place with a lot of lecture halls and books, it may not hold much appeal for them. However, if they see it as a place filled with labs, clinics, training rooms, studios, and practice rooms, this may be likely to attract them to higher education. (For some Virtuosos, this can also be attained just by choosing the right major at the right college.) They could find an apprenticeship in the working world, but college provides a "ready-made" opportunity to learn from others. Often, Virtuosos are attracted to occupations that need a certification or degree, and they have no other choice but to pursue higher education.

Virtuosos in College

Balanced College Learning

Free to Find Their Own Way

Virtuosos who attend a college or university are likely to feel set free. No longer bound by the rules of high school life, these students may finally find an educational model that fits their learning style. For many Virtuosos, leaving home and high school for college is a liberating experience.

Sometimes parents and guidance counselors, with all the best intentions, can send students in the wrong direction in college. But if Virtuosos didn't embrace more abstract, theoretical coursework in high school, the chances aren't any better for their doing so when they go to college. Instead, Virtuosos' course choices are likely to be the subjects they did connect with in high school, although anything that involves hands-on problem solving tends to attract these practical-minded individuals. Such subjects can enable them to avoid pressure from others (no matter how well-meaning) to choose majors and courses taught with the same one-size-fits-all learning style they faced in high school.

Unbalanced College Learning

Too Focused on "Right Now"

Some feel that attending a college or university is only about getting the tools to make a good living. While they appreciate the practical side of that motivation, most Virtuosos reject this as the primary reason to get a degree. Mastery and creativity are more likely to be the primary motivation for typical Virtuosos. Rightly or wrongly, they're usually convinced that their passion can see them through. However, Virtuosos with an unbalanced approach to learning may emphasize picking up skills in the "here and now" with little regard for the future.

Do Virtuosos look for "party schools" to enhance their university experiences? Like most young people, these types delight in the autonomy that going away to college offers. For most students, this is the first significant taste of life apart from their families – and their families' rules. Some even choose their universities based on their

distance from their family homes. It's no different for Virtuosos who are interested in coming into their own.

Although they can be rather outgoing as Introverts, a gregarious social life isn't likely to be very attractive to them. A few good friends tend to do just nicely. However, all students are susceptible to the temptations of college freedom, especially when they're under some emotional stress. Explorers all seek a little adventure and novelty, and this could draw Virtuosos into the campus party world, at least occasionally. They may want to exercise caution.

Rebalancing College Learning

Preparing for the Future

College is a time for Virtuosos to consider and exploit their strengths and talents in real ways. They can customize their courses of study enough to feel fulfilled, and this may include taking those courses no one wants to – the foundational, prerequisite courses. While there's often the option to "test out" of such courses, there are tremendous benefits to participating in them instead.

Learning to cope with dull or overly challenging courses is good disciplinary practice for Virtuosos. This isn't the only time in life they're likely to run into necessary tasks that feel meaningless and boring. College can help Virtuosos gain tolerance for such things and prepare them to approach the adult world in a more realistic manner.

Conclusion

In aiming for the mastery the name "Virtuoso" suggests, people with this personality type almost naturally embrace the role of lifelong learners. However, here again, successfully promoting learning for them in traditional classroom settings won't involve direct motivation or pushing them to improve their skills while hoping their interest ignites after the fact.

The trick is to help them find interactive disciplines that grab and inspire them up front. Once they discover such interests, Virtuosos are likely to

throw themselves into the learning process. Typically, when they find their niche, they look for ways to increase their skill levels on their own. With interest and passion in place, they may even find education, in a broader sense, more appealing.

Virtuosos can help themselves gain ground by understanding how education and training works for them. Nurturing and indulging their tendency toward curiosity can be beneficial as they search for their passions. Exploring with a purposeful emphasis on discovery and mastery can kick-start their educational – and perhaps professional – paths.

Professional Development

The Virtuoso personality is probably the most mysterious among all types, but it's also one of the most versatile personalities. The list of typical Virtuoso careers is an excellent reflection of their personality type – colorful, diverse, and unpredictable.

Relentlessly Pursuing Facts and Knowledge

One of the prominent Virtuoso traits is their curiosity, combined with their unquenchable thirst for facts and knowledge. They enjoy discovering how things work – and how martialing the right facts can solve difficult but practical problems.

One should never confuse Virtuosos' quest for facts and understanding with the more theoretical and abstract approach favored by academics. People with this personality type are very real-world oriented and prefer the "hands-on" approach. The best Virtuoso careers revolve around this. They're great mechanics, engineers, forensic scientists, etc. While they can work effectively in jobs that rely on theory if necessary, they're more at home with information that ends with them getting their hands dirty, either literally or metaphorically. They would rather act than ponder.

Driven by Independence

Virtuosos belong to the Explorer Role and need a lot of freedom in their work. If their work environment is too structured, they tend to quickly feel very tired and disinterested. There may be challenges in such jobs, but not the kind that excite Virtuosos. People with this personality type

like a lot of improvisation in their lives. Unfortunately, not every job can allow enough leeway for them to make things up as they go along.

Virtuosos are brilliant impromptu troubleshooters, and they don't mind taking risks. In some ways, they're born for crisis situations. People with this personality type commonly work in relatively risky careers where thinking on one's feet is a clear asset. They often become firefighters, paramedics, detectives, pilots, drivers, and so on.

Immediate Results

Virtuosos are very results-oriented, self-confident, and loyal. Long-term thinking isn't their strongest suit, and people with this personality type prefer to see instant results. They're also relaxed and are likely to avoid inflexible commitments. These traits are unusual, but some careers make very good use of them. For instance, Virtuosos can be outstanding police officers, freelance systems analysts, athletes, and entrepreneurs.

Unfortunately, despite being bold and very flexible, Virtuosos are likely to face many difficulties in their careers if they choose the wrong path. People with this personality type shine in very specific fields. They usually have difficulties coping in situations that don't utilize or recognize their efforts and strengths, as these Introverts may lack the assertiveness skills to promote their talents. Ultimately, job satisfaction can boil down to picking careers that are good matches for their traits and skills.

Jobs and Skill Sets

Below is an offering of jobs consistent with Virtuosos' traits. It's by no means comprehensive. That would be impossible, and the list would grow daily. We hope that the descriptions below can serve as guidelines for Virtuosos exploring new careers.

For those already employed, these suggestions may serve as a confirmation or explanation of why they might be happy or unhappy where they are. This offering doesn't presume to be a firm prescription of what they must do to succeed or be happy. Plenty of jobs are likely to work well for Virtuosos beyond those considered below. Rather, the following provides insights and broad guidelines that may help – but they're not meant to promote or limit any job or career for Virtuosos. The work of finding the best opportunities still lies with each unique job-seeker.

Arts and Crafts

Virtuosos love to be creative if it doesn't become too abstract or theoretical. Fine arts and crafts of all types appeal to their need for mastery and to tackle something new and different. Music can appeal to this personality type, and Virtuosos, true to their name, strive to become virtuosos should they find a career in music attractive.

While occasionally the arts demand group participation (an orchestra, for example), artists and artisans do most of their work as individuals, even when part of an ensemble. Painting a portrait or molding a ceramic pot is a solitary pursuit. Cellists, even those who belong to a group, practice for hours by themselves. This appeals to Virtuosos' preference for the freedom of working away from social pressure or "office politics." There's always a willingness to work with others if it doesn't infringe too much on their independent efforts.

People who earn a living creatively are more likely to be able to set their own agendas. Artistic Virtuosos can choose the compositions they want to create and form their purpose without concern about others interfering. They can take risks without worrying about the reactions or welfare of coworkers. These specific jobs fit the description well:

- Musician (any type: instrumental, composer, vocal, etc.)
- Potter
- Painter
- Illustrator
- Sculptor

- Graphic artist
- Weaver
- Interior designer
- Fashion designer
- Jewelry designer
- Metalsmith
- Photographer
- Woodworker
- Architect

Mechanics and Engineering

Positions in this area may appeal to Virtuosos' problem-solving natures, need for hands-on involvement, and drive to create and innovate. They're also practical professions where real objects act in real ways. While these fields are rich in practical ideas, they're almost devoid of the abstract and the theoretical. There are manuals with pictures and blueprints, and specific advisory steps to repair or maintain material items – concrete *things*. Math often comes into play but only in the most practical ways.

Engineers and mechanics often must collaborate with others and conform to rules. However, depending on their positions, they usually balance a portion of their time exploring how to create, fix, or improve something on their own and in their ways – this can provide Virtuosos their much-needed independence. Some specific occupations might include:

- Auto, boat, or airplane mechanic
- Small engine mechanic
- Appliance repair person
- Heavy equipment mechanic
- Engineer (mechanical, computer, structural, environmental, acoustic, robotic, aeronautic... any of the many branches of engineering)

Skilled Physical Labor

This category might include branches of the military, athletics, or perhaps driving, sailing, or flying people or cargo. Such hands-on jobs involve specialized skills and advanced planning abilities. Virtuosos may have to be careful about taking risks that affect teammates either on the battlefield or the playing field. Overall, in these positions, they'll get a sense of personal competence even while working with others. Careers in this area might include:

- Military professional (especially with a pronounced specialization)
- Athlete in any sport (individual rather than team sports may be more desirable for some Virtuosos)
- Pilot, captain, driver
- Transportation logistics
- Carpenter
- Brewer or wine maker

Medicine

Medical careers can afford Virtuosos opportunities to master skills, show rare expertise, and use problem-solving abilities. Discoveries in medicine are likely to offer much stimulation for Virtuosos as they devise new ways to use these breakthroughs. While they're likely to be better at problem-solving and the direct treatment of illness over softer skills like bedside manners, Virtuosos can be good doctors, especially in areas like surgery.

Challenging Career Qualities

In modern society, people not only spend a great deal of time at work, but they also allow their work to define them and provide some essential meaning for their lives. People need to be careful not to get stuck in situations that don't suit them, or they may experience a great many difficulties at work. Here are some job characteristics that may not be suitable for Virtuosos.

Mundane and Repetitive Work

Virtuosos are most comfortable with activities that involve novelty and spontaneity. Repetitive work of any kind simply falls short for them. They're great improvisers and easily become bored. Adding a widget repeatedly on an assembly line is likely to have limited appeal for Virtuosos.

Restrictive Environments

People with the Virtuoso personality type like to experiment and explore new ideas. If their workplace structure and rules are too rigid, they'll more than likely feel stifled and unfulfilled. They're problem-solvers and innovators and aren't happy when they can't exercise those passions. Virtuosos also like to take risks, which may be frowned upon in offices that are run too tightly "by the book."

Work That's Too Team-Dependent

Virtuosos' personal skills and prowess are very important to them – they're how they define themselves. These types perform well as part of a team, but only if they're also given enough opportunities to independently express their talents. Practical results are almost always more important than maintaining *esprit de corps* for them, and they're likely to go their own way if they believe such intended results are threatened. However, don't confuse this with an unwillingness to work in groups that contribute to their endeavors' effectiveness. In such cases, Virtuosos are often enthusiastic joiners.

People with this personality type rarely care about making friends in the office, seeing their work and duties as being far more important. Such an attitude isn't surprising – after all, it's their *modus operandi* in many other areas of their lives. But difficulty in developing casual relationships at work can stifle professional development and result in personal and professional missed opportunities.

Although people are likely to adapt to most situations given enough time, Virtuosos may want to think long and hard about putting themselves into highly social and interdependent situations. Depending on the level of individual autonomy within a team and Virtuosos' ability to withdraw from the group occasionally, team-centric environments just may not be the right fit.

Getting on the Career Ladder

Finding the Right Niche

Virtuosos are very adaptable. Even at school (which is usually a source of frustration for many), they're likely to improvise and experiment in ways that perplex more structured and conventional personality types. They typically decide matters on the spot and refuse to plan or prepare for contingencies. This ability to think on their feet is often a point of pride for Virtuosos – they may even see it as their superpower.

Like other Explorers, Virtuosos are unstoppable when they find a niche that gives them the freedom to choose their preferred course of action in all circumstances or an opportunity to master a specific technique. However, obtaining such opportunities may be a challenge.

Whatever their hobbies or aspirations, these types do best when they embrace roles on the front lines – be it operating tower cranes, selling cars, or piloting aircraft. What matters most is their desire to become masters of their techniques. Likely, these techniques are physical (e.g., working with tools or engaging in sports), although it isn't impossible that Virtuosos could use their skills in unexpected ways, such as by starting their own business. They thrive in risky, unpredictable situations, and this trait can be very useful in some jobs.

Lastly, Virtuosos should never forget to listen to themselves, especially when making career choices. They know what they want and are usually honest with themselves. But other factors often cloud their honesty – social pressures, for example. Family and friends may not understand their unique preferences. But they're the only ones who know what's going to make them happy.

This doesn't mean that they should have unrealistic expectations at the start of their career – entry level jobs are rarely interesting, or satisfying – but it's their responsibility to find the right career path. They shouldn't choose a profession just because it's popular or pays well, as it may not be a good match for their unique skills or principles. Virtuosos must have enough room to breathe to feel happy in their work environment. They aren't likely to be satisfied if they're constantly struggling in a field that stifles their need for independence. Their impulse to accomplish in their own way is too strong to be tightly tied to someone else's mandates.

Making Contact

Virtuosos should embrace their strengths in the job-hunting stage. Honestly, they're unlikely to do well networking and socializing, the primary means of getting a job for many other personality types. (Virtuosos can become better at this over time if they work to improve their social skills, however.)

There's a tendency to overgeneralize and put too much emphasis on certain skills when job-hunting. Ninja-level networking skills aren't mandatory by any means – this personality type can do just fine without an extensive social network. While embracing networking skills might make things easier, their adaptive skills can prove useful in helping them connect with the right jobs in their own ways.

Relating Outside Interests

Virtuosos' willingness to spend many hours honing their chosen crafts and their ability to cope with unexpected challenges may give them an unexpected leg up in the working world. In the right circumstances, people with this personality type should find it easy to show their prospective employers that they're very dedicated, capable, and trustworthy.

Virtuosos must be able to present their skills in the right way to distinguish themselves from other candidates. These types are likely to have serious interests they've turned into hobbies or pastimes. Finding engaging ways to use these pastimes during an interview can make all the difference when it comes to standing out from other candidates.

On the slight chance Virtuosos lack such interests and hobbies, there are plenty of activities that can not only pad their resumes but also round out their lives, such as participating in competitions or volunteer projects, or building personal websites dedicated to their favorite activities. Such items on their resumes make them more attractive and versatile candidates.

As a bonus, such topics and resume material can also give them some breathing space during intense interviews. Answering questions like, "Describe a situation where you used your problem-solving skills," is much easier if they have five such projects on their resume. However, it's up to Virtuosos to utilize them and push their accomplishments.

Preparing for the Interview

Virtuosos must also brush up on their presentation skills if they have an interview coming up. They shouldn't make the mistake of thinking their technical knowledge and enthusiasm can put them above everybody else. Instead, they can practice their responses to the most common interview techniques and questions so they aren't surprised by something like, "What's your biggest weakness?"

Virtuosos should try to highlight their achievements and knowledge, but also be prepared to answer many template questions, especially in early stages. Sometimes, recruiters may not know much about the jobs being offered and simply go through a checklist of prepared general questions. Virtuoso candidates should expect this and not let tunnel vision cloud their judgment.

Questions can address a wider range of topics than just their expertise. Sometimes, it's the generic questions that prove troublesome to those unprepared for them. All other things being equal, recruiters may hire lesser candidates who practice for the standard questions along with the job-specific ones over Virtuosos who know their stuff but clearly struggle with template interview questions.

Workplace Cooperation Between Roles

It's useful to have something in common when speaking with someone else. It can make the rest of the conversation more productive if you start with a resounding "yes," rather than a stubborn "no." The following sections cover possible pairings between Virtuosos and members of the other Role groups, including brief overviews of potential synergies and obstacles, and some tips that may help these types navigate tricky waters.

Virtuoso-Analyst Cooperation

Virtuosos and Analysts both like to search for answers, but their styles and scope of doing so are different. However, if both types recognize they're each looking for "better and more efficient ways" to work, it can make any discussions more productive. If they can grasp this, they may find that their motives are similar enough. Bonding through the things these personality types have in common, and learning the value of their differences, can go a long way in Virtuoso-Analyst business relationships.

Balanced Virtuoso-Analyst Cooperation

Different Paths to the Same Goal

While Analysts want to play with ideas and systems, Virtuosos would rather solve problems in a hands-on fashion. Analysts may not always see their ideas through to the end, but it's hard to get Virtuosos to wait long enough to check with others before they carry out theirs. One is more deliberative, while the other is somewhat rash. Virtuosos work with the "here and now," focusing on the practical, while Analysts work with overarching systems that are more conceptual than tangible and often extend into the future. If you want a real-world problem solved, there's nobody better than Virtuosos. If you want to know how to understand the system, deconstruct it, or build it better on paper, there's nobody like Analysts.

When Virtuosos and Analysts work together, they must understand that they're each part of a two-step process. Analysts can be weak at implementation while Virtuosos specialize in it. Virtuosos can put together the pieces that make Analysts' models work. Virtuosos sometimes don't pay enough attention to the "big picture," and focus

on the details, whereas their Analyst colleagues find this integral to their thinking. If each type understands they both have good things to stir into the same pot, Virtuosos and Analysts can create powerful working relationships.

Consider *Apollo 13*, the movie and real-life event that brought us the iconic phrase, "Houston, we have a problem." After a mechanical mishap, three U.S. astronauts were in danger of not making it back to Earth alive in their crippled space capsule. Analysts can be compared to ground control in Houston, who calculated all the numbers and worked out a trajectory. They created the system to get the astronauts home.

And the astronauts – Virtuosos in this scenario – were problem-solvers who did the hands-on work and brought about the swing around the Moon, which eventually got the capsule home. Communication between ground control and the astronauts was vital to the success of the rescue. This metaphor loosely demonstrates how Virtuosos' and Analysts' different functions and styles can work together to fulfill the same goals – particularly between theorists and craftspeople.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Analyst Cooperation

Diverse Focus

Analysts may become annoyed at Virtuosos' focus on details, while Virtuosos may feel Analysts' ideas are too vague and impractical. For Virtuosos, it's tempting to dismiss Analysts as having their heads in the clouds and not understanding the practical side of anything. Analysts may return such judgment by declaring that Virtuosos are reckless, have no vision, and think too narrowly about things. When either or both refuse to see the value of the other's style, communication is likely to shut down.

Analysts can be condescending if they don't feel someone can play skillfully in their cerebral playgrounds of lofty notions and complex systems. They may wrongly react to Virtuosos' focus on detail and simply write them off as uninspired. Meanwhile, Virtuosos are just as likely to ignore Analysts' "nonsense" as they move ahead and physically bring about everyday solutions. The result is that they both quit talking to each other, and that's a pitfall these coworkers may wish to avoid.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Analyst Cooperation

Sharing New Perspectives

Analysts become bored with too many concrete or mundane details. That doesn't mean that they have no use for them – it's just that such details aren't quite the center focus that they are for Virtuosos. But it's important for Virtuosos to understand that Analyst coworkers don't feel the need to dig into minutia as they do.

Virtuosos may want to ask their Analysts coworkers to give them feedback from their perspective. They may be surprised at how a bigger picture focus might help them define the tasks they're doing by providing a richer and broader viewpoint. A new perspective might save them from going off course, since they often ignore the larger vision. Analyst coworkers can be of immense help to them in this manner.

Virtuosos may want to carefully avoid dismissing their Analyst coworkers and their theories too quickly. They should remember that, despite all their lofty ideas, Analysts want the same things they do – the successful resolution of problems and challenges. Both types are puzzle solvers, but each has a different technique. It may help communication if Virtuosos learn to ask their Analyst coworkers more "why" questions.

Virtuoso-Diplomat Cooperation

Virtuosos (with their Observant and Thinking traits) and Diplomat coworkers (with their Intuitive and Feeling traits) may appear at cross purposes. Virtuosos' practical approach to life and problems and Diplomats' more idealistic bent seem likely to conflict with one another. However, if instead of thinking of their traits as opposites they each try to see them as complementary, there may be much potential for Virtuoso-Diplomat cooperation.

Balanced Virtuoso-Diplomat Cooperation

The common ground between Virtuosos and Diplomats is somewhat intangible, but they do share a similar attitude. Both enjoy a sense of moving forward and watching something become better. For Virtuosos, it's finding and implementing novel, interesting solutions to specific problems. Virtuosos can look at a tangled mess of a situation and figure out how to make it work – often in unique and innovative ways. For Diplomats, it's more broadly about personal growth, moral development, and well-being. They flip a fixed idea, make it more "human," and create a new perspective.

Both types share a respect for flexibility. Rules and traditions don't bind either type too tightly. While Virtuosos are much more practical and utilitarian when compared to Diplomats' idealistic pursuits of values, it's easy to imagine them sharing a common appreciation for innovation and change once each understands the other a little better.

Combining Vision with Craft

If Intuitive types and Observant types are open to each other's differences, partnerships between the two can offer a lot. Virtuosos excel at hands-on activities. They relish mastery of objects within their physical environment. Diplomats, as Intuitive types, are great at grasping, creating, and transforming ideas – especially those involving the human condition. Details can bore them if it looks like they're at the expense of higher values, whereas Virtuosos are fascinated by their functionality. Virtuosos want to know how they can manipulate each little piece and use it to create something new and better – especially if it meets a concrete need or feels like solving a puzzle. If you want a "vision," call on Diplomats. If you want Diplomats' visions realized in down-to-earth ways, call on Virtuosos.

Suppose Diplomat coworkers realize their organization's morale problem revolves around a need to create a greater sense of community and camaraderie. Communication is poor, and Diplomats sense a lack of connection among their clients and coworkers. Virtuoso coworkers might answer that realization by creating an email newsletter, a phone chain, a podcast, monthly coffee hours, or any of a dozen practical methods for pulling such communities together. They could create a brand around the organization that says "community" and, in doing so, also create a

team effort between Diplomats and Virtuosos. While Virtuosos continue to contribute the mechanisms, Diplomats can constantly evaluate the project's progress (and the mood of the stakeholders).

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Diplomat Cooperation

A False Dichotomy

While established standards don't bind either Virtuosos or Diplomats as tightly as they might bind Sentinels, Diplomats have unique codes by which they live. Their values, usually connected to their sense of empathy and compassion, are strong forces in their lives. While Virtuosos aren't amoral, values aren't always as prominent a consideration in the way they handle business. Results are more likely the measure they focus on.

For instance, Virtuosos tend to like people and are often friendly, outgoing, and fun. However, occasionally, they may see solving problems as more important than taking care of their colleagues' or clients' feelings or welfare. They may take risks, cut corners, or cavalierly develop plans that might have a negative impact on others. They may trust their instincts a little too much, doing something on their own without taking other people's opinions or standards into account. Such occasions can create conflicts between Virtuoso and Diplomat coworkers.

The Doers and the Dreamers

Diplomats may see Virtuosos as shallow, while Virtuosos may regard Diplomats as impractical dreamers. Virtuosos tend to live in the "here and now," while Diplomats live in the infinite time of imagination and thought. Diplomats are more likely concerned with long-range results while Virtuosos are more interested in immediate actions and solutions.

Let's use a hospital metaphor here. Diplomats would be the case managers equipped to handle patients' long-term well-being and create holistic treatment plans for them. Meanwhile, Virtuosos are down in the emergency room doing triage and reattaching limbs in their practical ways. Dissimilar views can create communication difficulties between the case managers and ER doctors because of their decidedly distinct interests and styles. However, someone running a hospital wants both around if they're going to save lives in the long- and short-term.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Diplomat Cooperation

Discovering Motivation

If Virtuosos want to discover what motivates their Diplomat coworkers, they can first try to discover their values. These coworkers are likely to extend their values and their ideals into their work lives as much as they reasonably can. The best way to communicate with them is to be careful not to bog them down with too many details or methods. These things hold little interest for Diplomats, who prefer talking about broader ideas. Virtuosos who want to find common ground with Diplomats may want to explore questions that start with, "What if?" (In return, Diplomats may want to ask questions that begin with, "How?")

As with all pairings of distinct types, Virtuosos and Diplomats working together do best if they learn to appreciate their differences. There's an economy among Roles which suggests that learning how to relate to different types with complementary traits is likely to bring forth the most effective results. For Virtuosos, it may mean allowing Diplomats to share their values and humanistic insight to give them larger perspectives. Virtuosos who accept such outlooks find that their work takes on more value and is a lot more accessible to those they impact, such as supervisors and clients.

Virtuoso-Sentinel Cooperation

It's easy to get the impression that Sentinels and Virtuosos are opposites, as they often approach things differently. But they aren't without some commonalities. They both prefer to gather information directly from the world around them, instead of filtering it through internal mechanisms – neither type has much interest in theories. While Virtuosos are more directly and immediately in touch with things,

Sentinels usually judge their experiences through remembering how things have always been. They're generally sticklers for rules and structures that support a traditional perspective. Virtuosos relish the new and exciting, while Sentinels favor the stable.

Balanced Virtuoso-Sentinel Cooperation

Something Old, Something New

Ironically, Virtuosos and Sentinels most often complement each other when things go wrong. Sometimes even the tried-and-true ways of doing things fail. This can be disconcerting to predictability-loving Sentinels, but a compelling situation for Virtuosos. In this ever-changing world, there are times when old methods no longer work. There may be no other choice other than to develop a new way of doing things – and there's no type better equipped to help when things need to be done quickly than Virtuosos.

Sometimes Virtuosos' impulsive drive to find solutions can get off track. Occasionally the best answer, when a situation goes bad, is to retreat to a known starting place. "Known places" are where Sentinels like to spend their time. Yes, sometimes, boldly "winging it" can lead to effective solutions – however, there are also times when such approaches create more problems than they solve.

From time to time, Sentinels can help Virtuosos "come home," figuratively speaking. Sentinels usually know how to repair a situation, or they know someone who does. This can be of great help to Virtuosos who've wandered too far in the wrong direction. If they rely on each other, rather than resist their differences, they can create effective partnerships, whether formally or informally.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Sentinel Cooperation

Clashing Styles

There are things about Virtuosos that drive Sentinels crazy, and, to a lesser degree, vice versa. Virtuosos have the advantage because they

usually go with the flow and don't worry much about what other people think. For Sentinels, however, their problems with Virtuosos can be disturbing.

While Virtuosos have no problem cutting corners when necessary, Sentinels usually dedicate their lives to making sure those corners remain intact – just the way they've always been. Sentinels like things to be orderly and predictable. Virtuosos have a freer attitude and love things that are new and interesting.

In life, Sentinels might prefer a favorite restaurant they go to most of the time, and Virtuosos are likely to sample all the latest restaurants the day they open. At work, Virtuosos can come across as reckless and undisciplined. To them, Sentinels might appear boring and uninspired. While their opinions of each other are usually more reactionary stereotypes than accurate assessments, such impressions can hinder trust and open communications.

Varied Regard for the Status Quo

While keeping the status quo firmly in place seems essential to Sentinels, Virtuosos have no problem doing what they feel is necessary to solve a problem regardless of "how it's always been done." Sentinels see tried-and-true means as the way to guarantee a predictable end. Only a successful end concerns Virtuosos, and they may use any means to get there.

It's easy to see how Sentinels can perceive Virtuosos being at cross purposes with them. They may devote an undue amount of time trying to get Virtuosos to walk a straight line according to the rules. Meanwhile, Virtuosos may ignore Sentinels as they do whatever they feel they must, either going in a straight line, serpentine, or any direction that helps them master the situation. The possibilities for conflicts are nearly endless.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Sentinel Cooperation

The Value of Protocols

As the philosopher George Santayana wrote, "Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it." Virtuosos can be too

quick to dismiss Sentinel attachments to the past and settled protocols. But there can be much to learn from their adherence to tradition and set standards. Virtuosos shouldn't be afraid to ask why they must do something a certain way – and Sentinels may want to avoid justifying an act or decision by saying anything that resembles, "Because we've always done it that way."

Mutual Learning

Accepting Sentinels' counsel may help avoid problems. Virtuosos may feel Sentinels somehow limit their options, and it may even be true. However, Virtuosos aren't likely to permanently lose their spontaneity and edgy creativity if they play by the rules occasionally. Relying on their Sentinel coworkers' sensitivity to guidelines and standards may help them stay around to create another day. (Sentinels may never ask for it, but they're always happy when someone shows appreciation. Doing so may be a way to create stronger working relationships between these two types.)

Virtuoso-Explorer Cooperation

Obviously, Virtuosos and other Explorers typically find themselves "speaking the same language." Theoretical and conceptual problems, which thrill Analysts, are just annoying to these types, who find no purpose in going there. Conversations about solving problems or mastering a skill or situation are of greater interest. Virtuosos and other Explorers gain energy and motivation from topics that revolve around overcoming a problem and saving the day.

Balanced Virtuoso-Explorer Cooperation

Whatever Gets the Job Done

Whatever gets the job done is what interests Virtuosos and Explorers who work together. They may bypass rules, standards, or traditions that block the way of their focus and strategies. Because of this, and their pronounced spontaneity and independence, others often see them as risk-takers.

Virtuosos are comfortable with other Explorers also seeking to do things their way. They like talking about the new and the different – if these discussions focus on tangible matters and don't wander into the arena of abstract theories. While people belonging to these types might appreciate talking about the capabilities of the new iPhone, they're likely to show less interest in a discussion of the future sociological impact of constant digital communications worldwide. They might share a sense of satisfaction if they figure out a unique use for the phone's technology. The second topic would be "just talk" to this action-oriented group.

Practical Innovation

Virtuosos and Explorers brought together within teams are likely to become brainstorming powerhouses within their companies. They wouldn't only resolve problems, but also innovate and add to the growth of their organizations – but only as it affects methods. The harnessed energy of Virtuosos and Explorers who bounce ideas off each other would be a formidable asset to any organization.

Virtuoso and Explorer coworkers are likely to make any joint discoveries on the run and are more likely to do so by applying their hands to problems rather than drawing out diagrams and steps on a whiteboard.

Unbalanced Virtuoso-Explorer Cooperation

But at What Cost?

The problems that occur between Virtuosos and Explorers likely have nothing to do with mutual understanding. Instead, they may become stuck in their shared style, without the benefit of insights from those who tend to deliberate a while before acting. In business and life, it's good to have varied personality types around for balance.

On the off-chance that work becomes too "Explorer-heavy," several factors can be problematic. Grace Hopper, the late computer scientist and United States Navy Rear Admiral, famously said, "It's easier to apologize than to get permission." Virtuosos and Explorers often take this quote to heart, resulting too often in their running into trouble with those in authority. Their willingness to take different paths and risks to find unique solutions can be an asset in the workplace in small measure. However, it shouldn't go unchecked.

Just like their risk-taking, the often-complex relationships Virtuosos and Explorers have with their coworkers may also need tempering. While they often enjoy and care about other people, they just as often put practical solutions ahead of the feelings and concerns of others. They may come across as having a brusque disregard for their coworkers. They place people below solutions on their list of priorities. "It can't be helped," is likely to be the shared excuse between Virtuosos and their Explorer accomplices – provided they even discuss such matters. This might create a gulf between them and other coworkers.

Solutions with a Small Perspective

Virtuosos and Explorers might also find that their actions don't align with the larger vision of their organizations. Being detail-oriented and thinking in the present, these similar types may disregard the larger view of their firms' goals and focus. Just as it takes one degree of a compass to send a ship hundreds of miles off course, so can a small misguided solution potentially disrupt a company's larger goals.

To Virtuosos working with other Explorers, their solutions may seem reasonable. To their supervisors, it can appear as though they're thumbing their noses at the vision and values of their company. If not adjusted for, the immediacy of their shared mindset can create a tunnel vision that ignores matters that are highly significant to those in charge.

Rebalancing Virtuoso-Explorer Cooperation

Commonalities and Moderating Influences

It's always enjoyable when like minds work together. It's likely Virtuoso and Explorer coworkers enjoy simply spending time talking to each

other, but they should also consider using this time to brainstorm new and better ways of doing things. The experience can go up a notch if they find something to tinker with while they're chatting.

Every personality type can benefit from the balance provided by other types. When two types are so similar and comfortable with each other's great ideas, a second opinion from someone more "mainstream" can be useful. Even Virtuosos and their Explorer teammates can grow as individuals and as teams when they expand their comfort zones by exploring different approaches – even if they're sometimes more conventional than they prefer.

Virtuosos and Explorers who work together may find that they're quite comfortable exploring the "How?" questions involved in finding a solution. To rebalance their efforts and keep them beneficial rather than harmful, learning to ask "Why?" may be just as essential. This may again require a second opinion from someone who's more in touch with the bigger picture.

Conclusion

Virtuosos can be paradoxes in the workplace. They're happy to work on a team if such collaboration assures results, but they're also just as comfortable working alone. Even within a team, they need to exercise independence. Their personal skills must feel autonomous, as they're essential to their happiness and motivate them to produce and succeed. If a job feels like overstructured conformity based on unskilled actions, Virtuosos won't be able to access that part of themselves that responds in healthy ways to challenges.

To thrive in the workplace, Virtuosos must find a niche that's their own. Most are good at this, having practiced it while dealing with school systems focused on more conventional things than they, as young people, could relate to. While not always adept at commitment in any traditional sense in their personal lives, once they find their career niche, they're usually ready to settle down for the duration. This allows them to become highly skilled and often specialized – making them valued workers and professionals in many fields.

Final Words

The world – including schools and workplaces – would be far more boring without Virtuosos. Curious and adventurous, people with this personality type are willing to push the boundaries that keep most other people in line, and the results can be nothing short of impressive.

School and work are not always thrilling, especially for Virtuosos, who are endlessly curious but just don't operate on the strength of theory alone. They are, at their core, lifelong learners always seeking to hone their skills in a practical sense. And while they often think of "skill" as more of a mechanical ability, they must take care not to forget about the soft skills that life (and success) require.

One of those skills is learning to cope with the dull, unexciting aspects of their chosen path. Another is recognizing that they are, indeed, on a path. Virtuosos rarely do what they do thinking of the long-term payoff, but if they stretch their creativity to develop a big-picture sense of where their talent can take them, there is nothing that they can't accomplish.

In these pages, we've offered insights and guidance that can help even the most independent Virtuosos channel their natural strengths and talents into the stimulating and satisfying career that they deserve. Interest and passion are their fuel, which when harnessed, can carry them to the apex of mastery in whatever field they settle in.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you excel in your career? Explore our Career Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your relationships? Check out the *Virtuoso Guide to Relationships*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? Our *Virtuoso Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

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